

Wikipedia mobile

On July 9, Wikipedia moved the mobile version of the site out of beta testing. The site is available at m.wikipedia.org



Welcome to Wikipedia,
the free encyclopedia that anyone can edit.
2,949,142 articles in English

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WIKIPEDIA

behind the pages

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A quick and dirty history of wikis

Wikis are web pages that allow visitors and users to change the content of the web page. This is achieved through the agency of server-side programs that are known as wikis. Every Wikipedia-like web site is based on a wiki engine, that allows users to edit the content. The first wiki engine was written in Perl by Ward Cunningham, for his programming web site. This was way back in 1995, and the web site was used by programmers for

sharing ideas. This was called the WikiWikiWeb, and the name was chosen from the Hawaiian word for "quick". This simply intended for content to be generated rapidly, but Ward Cunningham had no clue how rapidly. Wiki-based sites took quite some time to take off though. Between 1995 and 2000, a few other wiki-based web sites came out, many written in other languages, but none of these really reached out to a massive number of people.

This was still the first decade of the web's existence, and we should factor in the lack of penetration of the web on a global scale. Wiki engines were written in PHP, Java, Perl, and a number of other programming languages, and were used by some web sites with a mediocre amount of success. Wikis at that time didn't stand out as an innovative new approach to content generation, and as such, their potential was not realised. A notable exception was senseis.xmp.net, a large web site dedicated to the chequers-like game of go, which has a large number of tactics, strategies and playing configurations.

Enter Jimmy Wales, who worked on a free online encyclopaedia project called

Nupedia. The content was generated by readers, and moderated by editors chosen for the job. To increase the number of articles, Jimmy Wales started a wiki-based encyclopedia, called it Wikipedia, and launched it in January 2001, just when internet junkies around the world were logging on to web 2.0. Wikipedia used MediaWiki, a PHP-based wiki. Six months and a thousand articles later, a link to Wikipedia was put up on Slashdot. Hoards of users jumped into the fray, and increased the article count to a staggering 20,000 articles by the end of the year. Wikipedia has been growing at an exponential rate ever since.

All of this, however, is ancient history. The nature and philosophy of wikis has evolved since 2002, a culture, a complex system of rewards and a set of protocols have evolved since then. Wikipedia has spawned a number of sister sites, including WikiNews, WikiText and WikTionary. Wikis have grown beyond Wikipedia too, with hundreds of highly specific and fan-run wikis always in continuous movement. A large number of people know Wikis from the outside, and have no clue about the drama behind the pages they refer to.

The Wiki hierarchy

Despite all its apparent openness, the wikipedia editors have a notoriously strict set of principles, an irritating sense of altruism, and a strange and semi-official hierarchy based on their contributions to Wikipedia. Many editors casually change a few wrong spellings, improper language, or factual errors as and when they come across them. There are however, a dedicated number of editors who have taken it upon themselves to be responsible for the Wikipedia of their language. Disputes are not infrequent, and are often settled using votes.

Editors are also democratically chosen and promoted to higher levels – these give them more access to the web pages, power over other editors and users, and a host of tools to use at their disposal. The editors are at the lowest rung here, and many are happy to stay there. However, quite a few ascend to the level of Sysop or administrator. These are editors with extra powers over Wikipedia. They can change the locked or "protected" pages on Wikipedia, including deciding what goes on the home page of the web site. In the beginning of Wikipedia, all users had universal access, and everybody functioned as Sysops. In theory, this is still true, but in practice, some people have more privileges because of the size and scope of the project.

Bureaucrats are far fewer in number than the Sysops or editors, and have more power. They can settle disputes, appoint other bureaucrats, and have more

Some service awards

The categorisation Barnstar

The categorisation Barnstar, awarded by editors to people who categorise articles, or maintain and structure the existing category pages on Wikipedia

DYK Medal

The DYK medal, awarded to those editors with significant contribution to the Did You Know section of Wikipedia. These appear as pointers right below the featured story of the day on the front page of Wikipedia]

Senior Editor

The badge editors can display on their user pages after 24,000 edits on Wikipedia after four years. The editor is considered to be either the senior editor or have the improbable title of "Grand and Glorious Tutnum of the Encyclopedia"

